EW Project Abstract

Building Resilient Entrepreneurs: Key Dimensions of Startup Survival and Gamified Learning in Preparing for Uncertain Futures

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ABSTRACT

Early-stage startups operate in highly uncertain and volatile environments characterized by resource scarcity, structural fragility, and high failure rates. While structural disadvantages such as the liability of newness and the liability of smallness explain why young ventures are particularly vulnerable, less clarity exists regarding which specific dimensions of resilience are most critical for their survival and adaptability. The purpose of this study is to develop a structured, multi-dimensional understanding of startup resilience and to empirically examine how different resilience dimensions contribute to early-stage venture sustainability. Building on entrepreneurship and organizational theory, resilience is conceptualized as a dynamic adaptation process encompassing psychological (founder and team resilience), behavioral (adaptive decision-making and pivoting), organizational (internal structures and processes), and relational (networks and ecosystem embeddedness) dimensions. To investigate their perceived relevance, a quantitative survey was conducted among early-stage founders and startup teams. A structured questionnaire was developed based on the theoretical framework. The data were analyzed using descriptive statistics and mean comparisons to identify and rank the most critical resilience dimensions. Consequently, the study explores whether gamified learning approaches may represent a potential tool for developing resilience-related capabilities in an entrepreneurial context.

The results indicate that resilience in startups is not a single capability but a multi-dimensional construct in which psychological and behavioral dimensions are perceived as particularly critical during early venture stages, while organizational and relational aspects gain importance as ventures mature. The findings suggest that individual founder resilience and adaptive decision-making play a central role in navigating uncertainty, whereas structural processes and ecosystem integration provide stabilizing effects over time. Overall, the study highlights resilience as a strategic capability that enables startups to absorb shocks, adapt proactively, and sustain long-term adaptability in uncertain environments.

Keywords: *Startup resilience, Entrepreneurial adaptability, Resilience Dimensions, Gamification*